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H2. Understanding the Options

Canadian colleges and institutes deliver a broad range of applied, hands-on education tailored to the current job market. These institutions of practical learning are variably called colleges, institutes of technology, polytechnics, colleges of applied arts and technology, community colleges, institutes, or Collège d'enseignement général et professionnel (Cégep in Quebec).

Such institutions work hand-in-hand with industry to ensure that students are prepared to take advantage of current and emerging job market opportunities and secure key roles in industry, whether in Canada, North America, or abroad. Graduates are leaders in industry the world over. Their sought-after skills and education are transferable and globally recognised.

Colleges and institutes take advantage of their strong linkages with the private sector to develop state-of-the-art applied research programs. A key component of providing market-ready skills is giving students the opportunity to work with their future employers. Thanks to strong connections with employers in the regions they serve, colleges and institutes offer students a diverse range of work-integrated learning opportunities, from co-ops and internships to apprenticeships, field placements, applied research projects, and service learning.

These institutions offer a wide range of credentials, including bachelor's degrees, diplomas, apprenticeships, certificates, graduate offerings, continuing education and corporate training, any of which may include a co-op and/or an internship. For example:

- One-year post-graduate professional certificates of specialisation
- Two- or three-year diplomas in technology or business
- Four-year applied bachelor's degrees with internships

- English and/or French language studies
- Four-year combined college/institute and university diplomas and degrees (two credentials for one program of study)

Colleges and institutes are highly accessible offering high-quality education at over 670 locations across Canada — from urban centres to remote communities— including campuses, and research, training, and access centres. In fact, 95% of Canada's population lives within 50 kilometres of a Colleges and Institutes Canada member institution. Programs are offered in French, English, or both depending on the region. Many also offer combined distance learning opportunities.

Over 10,000 programs with varying lengths of required study are offered nationwide. One unique offering is the one-year post-graduate certificates available to Canadian and international university graduates who wish to acquire applied and advanced skills for specific areas of employment.

Examples of post-graduate programs with a specialised focus on current industry practices leading to high employability of graduates:

- Global Business Management
- Renewable Energy
- Entrepreneurship
- Electronic Game Design
- Health Information Management

Another unique offering are the three- to four-year bachelor's degrees that provide job-focused education in a variety of fields. Examples of bachelor's degrees with an applied focus in a particular field include:

- Bachelor of Applied Technology in Industrial Design
- Bachelor of Applied Business in E-Commerce
- Bachelor of Arts in Criminal Justice
- Bachelor of Applied Information Systems Technology

The college/institute school year is the same as other post-secondary calendars, running from September through April or May, with spring and summer courses often available. Some institutions have a semester or trimester system allowing students to begin programs in September, January, or May. Quebec Cégeps offer two streams of education: three-year

vocational and two-year pre-university programs. They also offer flexible post-graduate and continuous education options.

Canadian college credentials are approved by provincial or territorial governments. Programs may also be accredited by independent industry or professional employer organisations. To ensure rigorous academic quality, the provincial ministries of education determine which institutions are allowed to offer which credentials.

Why Would International Students Choose a College or Institute?

Colleges and institutes work closely with industry to ensure courses reflect the skill requirements that employers need. They will provide practical training and work experience through work placements, and internships. This hands-on training ensures students move beyond academic learning to apply and test their skills in real workplace settings.

Colleges and institutes offer a vast range of programs from certificates, diplomas, and degrees to graduate certificates that drive innovation in a number of cutting-edge fields and economic sectors, including information communications and technology (ICT), clean technology, and blockchain technology. They are also leaders in the delivery of e-learning technology and curriculum.

Many colleges and institutes across Canada involve students in applied research projects conducted with local businesses. This enriched learning experience exposes students to real-world innovation challenges and establishing key contacts within industry for potential job opportunities.

Some colleges offer transfer programs that enable participants to complete courses through the college and then later transfer into a university or another college, with credit towards their future university degrees. Thus colleges can either be the full educational experience for an international student, or a part, if the student wants both college and university education. Under a university transfer arrangement, the student would typically do one or two years at a college and then two years at a university. The benefits to the international student of such a transfer arrangement are:

- Smaller classes at the beginning (during the college portion of the study program), with more support;
- A more applied and practical study program than university alone, with opportunities for placements with industry while at college;
- A lower cost than university alone.

In addition, to gain in-demand skills and practical work experience, many university graduates choose to complement their degree with a college/institute diploma. In Ontario alone, 42% of international students enrolled at a college/institute—most often for one-year post-graduate certificates of specialisation with internships—have a university degree.

Information International Students Will Need to Know When Considering Colleges/Institutes

When it comes to exploring college/institute options, international students:

- May already have some experience in the field of study. They may want to study at a Canadian college/institute or polytechnic to upgrade their credentials or improve their job prospects. Or, they may have no experience at all. The agent will face a variety of student profiles when it comes to those interested in college or institute education.
- Will be as interested in program and/or degree options as the institution itself when they consider a college or institute education.
- Will care about the length of time various program options require (for example, a diploma will take less time than a degree).
- May be interested in the transferability of college/institute credits or degrees to universities particularly if they already hold college or university credentials from their home country and seek an expedited education that will quickly provide transferability of credentials and knowledge for employment.

The program offerings and types of credential offered will vary widely across institutions. It is crucial for the agent to research these carefully before advising the student on study choices.

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